

perpetrators of 26/11 not just roaming free but making public speeches on attacking India. New Delhi's main grouse is that US pressure on Islamabad does not seem to be working. "In the past, US military assistance to Pakistan has been used against India and we believe that any fresh assistance may be misused," Rao told US officials, including National Security Adviser General Jim Jones. At a meeting with US Under Secretary Bill Burns, where Secretary of State Hillary Clinton also dropped by, Rao explained that despite India taking the first step and inviting Pakistan for foreign secretary-level talks, Pakistan has not acted in trying to meet India's concerns on terrorism and has continued its hostile anti-India campaign in Afghanistan, illustrated by the recent bombing of the Kabul guest house that killed several Indians. In anticipation of the Pakistan delegation's visit, Rao cautioned that military aid to Pakistan was certain to be used against India, as has

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RAO AND INDIAN AMBASSADOR
JAYANT PRASAD IN KABUL
AFTER THE ATTACK



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NIRUPAMA RAO, *Foreign Secretary*

happened in the past. And with Pakistan seeking a nuclear deal with the US on the lines of the Indo-US nuclear deal, India's anxiety is peaking.

What may add further to the growing mistrust is the deal made to the key 26/11 plotter David Headley. Headley has confessed to played a role in planning the Mumbai attacks but the confusion on giving access to Indian interrogators for quizzing him has only raised doubts in New Delhi about Washington's real intentions. Besides Headley's confession, the plea agreement allows Headley considerable flexibility. He has agreed to fully and willfully participate in any debriefings for the purpose of gathering intelligence or national security information or any foreign judicial proceedings held in the US by way of deposition, video conferencing or letters rogatory, which effectively rules out any scope of

extradition to India. Senior Indian officials believe that Headley may have been an agent of the CIA which is why they are reluctant to expose him to Indian interrogators. "Headley must be punished severely but we are yet to get any assurances from the US about India getting access to Headley," External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna told INDIA TODAY. US Ambassador Timothy J. Roemer has stated that the US Department of Justice will work with the Government of India regarding the modalities of such cooperation.

However, senior US officials point out that security cooperation between India and the US has been unprecedented post the 26/11 Mumbai attacks. An FBI official deposed in the trial and the joint investigation by the two countries led to the arrest of seven conspirators in Pakistan, Headley as well as his accomplice

Tahawwur Rana in the US. But it is access to Headley that is causing disquiet in New Delhi. Sources say that while a team of Indian officials could not quiz Headley in the US in the pre-trial stage, a team of Danish investigators looking into his involvement in a plot to kill the Danish cartoonist were given access. Adding to all, there is the ticklish issue of Afghanistan where India feels let down after the Washington-led policy of doing business with the so-called "good Taliban" in Afghanistan was decided at the London conference where India was elbowed out. Now, India finds itself further marginalised after the US decided to do business with leaders like the Taliban's former foreign minister Wakil Ahmed Muttawakil who played a dubious role during the IC-814 hijack to Kandahar in December 1999. Even though the US has given assurances that it is not preparing an exit strategy to get out of Afghanistan in 2011, India is worried that the US strategy to woo the Taliban runs parallel to its policy to appease Pakistan which will undermine India's role and heavy diplomatic and financial investment in Afghanistan.

In fact, emboldened by US support, Pakistan may now assume a central role